

Investigating User Perceptions of Mental Health Content on TikTok: A Comprehensive Exploration

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ABSTRACT

This paper explores the landscape of mental health (MH) content on TikTok, a rapidly growing social media (SM) platform. Examining TikTok's unique attributes, including its algorithm, format, and user dynamics, I analyze its role in fostering open discussions on MH. Despite its potential benefits, concerns such as the algorithmic bubble, transparency issues, and misinformation spread are highlighted. My study emphasizes the intricate relationship between TikTok's algorithmic content delivery, user behavior, and MH discourse. I propose design implications to balance personalized content delivery and responsible information dissemination. Insights from in-depth interviews with experienced TikTok users in MH content provide valuable perspectives for the HCI research community to support users engaging with and consuming MH-related content on TikTok.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → *Empirical studies in HCI*.

KEYWORDS

Mental Health, Social Media, Interview, TikTok, Algorithm

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1 BACKGROUND

TikTok, a video-sharing SM app owned by Chinese tech giant ByteDance, has seen a spike in active user numbers [9]. The app has become the go-to platform amongst younger generations for discussions on various topics, including MH [4]. TikTok's popularity is partly thanks to its unique combination of a short-form video format and an algorithm-based recommendation system. TikTok predominantly presents content to users through its "For You Page" (FYP), creating a streamlined content-recommendation experience

tailored to a specific user on an infinite loop [33]. The algorithm-driven content has been shown to significantly influence users' self-concept and community engagement [12, 23, 29].

The social network stands out as a platform where emotional expression and authenticity are encouraged and accepted norms [13]. In contrast, some other social media platforms tend to discourage the sharing of difficult emotions [5, 37]. Users perceive TikTok as a secure environment for expressing their identity and connecting with communities that foster a sense of belonging and trust [27, 28]. This sense of security and authenticity is attributed to the relative anonymity of the TikTok audience, which primarily consists of strangers [6].

TikTok's acclaim extends to its user-generated content, significantly contributing to MH understanding and awareness [20, 24]. Much of this content aims to destigmatize MH discourse [36]. With the destigmatisation of the MH discourse, there's a concern about overgeneralizing mental illnesses [23]. Users have shown to struggle to call out misinformation during moments of vulnerable self-disclosure, acknowledging content creators' pursuit of virality while respecting personal experiences shared [11, 30]. Recognizing the possible risks associated with harmful MH content and misinformation is essential since being exposed to inaccurate MH information on SM can reinforce misconceptions and undermine legitimate sources [21]. Observations and research note individuals on TikTok may self-diagnose based on concise videos, raising questions about accuracy and usefulness [8, 15, 32] due to the content consisting of unaudited and deceptive information [19].

Finally, understanding the application's impact on shaping MH discourse is crucial. The modality of SM plays a significant role in shaping site norms [6], with different mediums carrying varying degrees of nonverbal cues important for authenticity and emotion [17, 31]. TikTok's videos as a media create an ideal structure for self-disclosure and MH discourse [26], but other platform-specific features like stitches and video replies remain unexplored [1, 2]. Therefore, it is essential to understand how TikTok's users engage with this information empirically, what constitutes this kind of content and culture to prosper on the platform, and the influence this has on its users. While prior studies covered various SM platforms, my focus is TikTok, examining how its format and algorithms influence MH discussions. This study aims to answer the following research questions to address this task:

- **RQ1.** How do the attributes and features of TikTok contribute to the thriving presence and user interaction with MH content on the platform?
- **RQ2.** What are the perceived benefits and risks for users' well-being when engaging with and relying on TikTok as an MH platform?

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2 METHODOLOGY

I employed a qualitative research approach to address the proposed research questions to gain a deeper understanding of users' interaction with MH on TikTok. I conducted 10 semi-structured interviews with individuals actively engaging with or creating MH content on TikTok, ensuring ethical approval from the University of Zurich Ethics Commission. I employed diverse recruitment methods, including email outreach, snowball sampling, SM outreach, and distributing flyers both online and offline. This multi-channel approach aimed to reach individuals actively involved with the application while ensuring the inclusion of those who might not be easily discoverable solely through the app.

For the recruitment on TikTok, I did the following: TikTok's search function was used to find relevant videos on TikTok using the following keywords: "mental health (advice) (awareness)", "depression (advice) (awareness) (signs)", "anxiety (advice) (awareness) (signs)". Relevant video creators were contacted, and approximately 30 to 50 individuals who commented on videos were also contacted. The recruitment message explained the study's goal, offering compensation. Interested individuals meeting eligibility criteria (above 18 years, prior TikTok experience, engagement with MH content) expressed interest and signed a consent form. The scheduled interviews were conducted via Zoom or in person at the University of Zurich from June 4th to June 25th, 2023. Supervised by my mentor, I continued recruitment until achieving theoretical saturation [10]. The 10 participants ranged from 23 to 27 years of age, with the average age of my participants being $M = 25.3$. I had equal distributions of self-identified genders amongst my participants, with five identifying as female and five identifying as male. I employed one-to-one semi-structured interviews in English, German, or Swiss German, using an interview protocol that was created in advance and revised several times with senior members of my lab. The interviews ranged from 40 to 90 minutes and were audio recorded and fully transcribed using HappyScribe ¹.

2.1 Data Analysis

The research involves interview transcripts, memos, and codes, following Charmaz et al.'s constructivist grounded theory [10]. Using a thematic analysis approach [7] with an inductive coding strategy [10, 18], the process included data familiarization, inductive code generation, theme identification, and collaborative discussions. Initial coding used Taguette ², resulting in 229 candidate codes refined into 201 axial codes. Connections between codes identified key themes and concepts [22]. A Miro ³ board organized codes into clusters, forming candidate themes. Collaborative deliberation with my supervisor led to a final coding tree with 38 high-level codes, revealing two main themes: (i) *Content Engagement and Its Impacts*, and (ii) *Impact of Personalized Content Delivery on Format and User Engagement*.

2.2 Positionality Statement

Being the author, and having personal MH experience, influenced the research approach and connection with participants, although

this information was not disclosed to my participants due to ethical considerations. My supervisor and I actively participate in MH communities and have prior research experience, contributing to study design and refinement. My personal knowledge of MH brings valuable insights into participants' experiences in that it allows me to approach them empathetically and relate to their responses to a certain degree but also acknowledge that personal encounters with MH can influence the study's outcomes.

3 RESULTS AND FINDINGS

I outline two themes derived from my dataset. The first, *Content Engagement and Its Impacts*, addresses RQ1, exploring TikTok's MH culture and examining TikTok-specific factors that influence MH content interaction. The second, *Impact of Personalized Content Delivery on Format and User Engagement*, responds to RQ2 by examining the potential drawbacks of hosting MH content on TikTok.

3.1 Content Engagement and Its Impacts

The insights derived from TikTok users actively engaging with MH content contribute to a deeper understanding of why TikTok is perceived as an inclusive platform for MH discussions.

3.1.1 Algorithmic Delivery and Its Effects. Algorithmic delivery done through the FYP plays a pivotal role in users' content consumption on TikTok. While some actively search for specific content, the algorithm significantly shapes users' experiences. According to one participant, "80% of the time it is the algorithm. It is really uncanny how TikTok actually knows what I want and how. And 20% I really search myself" [P1]. Creators express confidence that their content will reach the right audience, fostering a sense of community. As one participant described, "You get recommended the best motivation video that you need in this specific moment. You look to the comment, and you feel less alone somehow" [P6]. This discovery of content, not actively sought but appreciated, contributes to TikTok's unique MH culture, where creators believe their messages will resonate with the intended audience.

3.1.2 Vulnerability and Personability. TikTok's anonymity fosters an environment where users feel comfortable expressing authentic thoughts openly, a contrast to platforms like Instagram. The blend of anonymity and algorithmic support allows tailored content for specific niches while maintaining a connection with a broader audience, as highlighted by one participant's observation that, "[The video] was kind of pretty specific... but of course, most TikTok videos are also so generalized that they're still kind of for the masses" [P1]. Creators often reveal personal struggles in their videos, making the platform feel more genuine. According to one participant, this aspect feels "more human in the sense that everyone has their personal challenge, their personal problem" [P6]. This personal touch extends to content based on creators' personal experiences, contributing to a relatable and encouraging atmosphere. As one participant shared, "[I am posting content] because I also experienced it, so I do not want other people to experience it as well... I think it will help them to solve their problems" [P8].

The emotional impact of MH content on users is noteworthy. Positive reactions include feelings of companionship, with one

¹<https://www.happyscribe.com/>

²<https://www.taguette.org/>

³<https://miro.com/>

participant expressing, *"There are many other people who feel the same way, and then you probably do not feel so alone in this situation"* [P7]. Users generally enjoy engaging with MH content, finding it uplifting. Reading comments by other users further enhances this experience, as users express compassion and engage with each other, fostering a sense of community. One participant highlighted the importance of comments, stating, *"You look to the comments, and you feel less alone somehow"* [P6].

3.1.3 Interaction Between Content and Users. Users who enjoy MH content on TikTok often show their appreciation by liking videos. Some use the save feature to create collections like "Motivation" [P1]. However, challenges arise because people sometimes forget to save these collections. Saving also influences FYP content, as one user mentions, *"[...] I bookmarked it. [...] The algorithm has somehow learned that I like this kind of content"* [P6]. Attempts to curate the FYP by following creators or reporting unwanted videos do not significantly affect content recommendations. P1 prefers YouTube Shorts, citing the consideration of active subscriptions. Following creators on TikTok is seen as a gesture of support and praise rather than a direct influence on content recommendations: *"[...] when I follow someone, I feel like I am supporting that person"* [P4].

3.1.4 TikTok Goes Too Far. Users resort to reporting unwanted content, expressing their interest in influencing recommendations: *"[...] I chose the one that said, 'This does not interest me' or 'Do not show me this anymore'"* [P7]. Encountering sudden shifts from light-hearted content to profound MH discussions while using the app for entertainment can be jarring: *"You didn't expect it. You were just watching some fun videos, and suddenly something so severe appeared"* [P4]. Users acknowledge that this abrupt change may trigger negative responses, particularly for those with fragile MH: *"Those who are not as strong might let themselves fall into a void much faster"* [P3]. Some users cope with the unexpected content by using the app less or switching to other platforms: *"All of a sudden I got a whole list. But I think that was when I closed the app. Those are the moments that make you think, 'Wow, what am I doing here?'"* [P4].

3.2 Impact of Personalized Content Delivery on Format and User Engagement

In exploring the impact of MH content on user reactions and behaviors, my interest extended to determining whether the information gathered triggered significant changes in user behavior.

3.2.1 Challenges of Applying Advice. Most users found the MH videos insightful but struggled to apply the recommended advice, citing challenges such as its generalization: *"[...] That it is too generalized. That it applies to a lot of people and is too imprecise."* [P10]. Users felt that some advice was unattainable, which was more discouraging than encouraging: *"I would say that sometimes it helps to see the silver lining [...]. But then sometimes you might see a video and you go, oh, instead of motivating you, it brings you down"* [P6]. In addition, some recommendations seemed to have false reasoning, undermining trust in TikTok's advice: *"For example, you had a heartbreak. And then there were tips, okay, 'How can you rekindle the fire?' And I was like, no, we do not want to do that right now"* [P1]. Overall, the solutions presented felt oversimplified and extreme to

some users, leaving a bad impression: *"[...] 50% really helped me, and the other 50% is more like, okay, yeah, this is too extreme for me, and it kind of doesn't fit the situation, or they just seem really delusional"* [P1].

3.2.2 Information Verification Practices and Discourse Dynamics. Users on TikTok navigate information verification primarily by examining comments and sometimes the identity of the creator based on their profile description to assess credibility. Opinions are formed by observing the reactions of others, with some participants trusting content more if the majority of comments agree [P10]. Despite the reliance on comments, participants extend verification beyond TikTok to include real-life connections, Internet searches, and cross-platform checks on platforms such as Instagram. Notably, TikTok lacks platform-specific features for verifying information: *"Does this mean that TikTok itself doesn't contribute anything, that you can say this is true and this isn't, it's more the people who post something decisive?"* "Yes, I would say so" [P3].

In terms of critical discourse, TikTok's community is thought to keep users in like-minded bubbles, limiting challenging discussions and encouraging extremes of opinion: *"There's never a middle ground. I only see one extreme now, either very, very strong agreement or very strong disagreement"* [P1]. This lack of middle ground raises concerns about the platform's susceptibility to manipulation, as my interviewers feel that the app's users are easily influenced [P1][P3]. Participants also noticed a shift in the filtering of comments, away from the previous chronological listing [P7]. While participants asserted their critical thinking skills, attributions varied, including education, Internet experience, and cultural upbringing [P4][P7][P9].

4 DISCUSSION

The following sections will delve into the learnings I drew from TikTok as an MH platform through a structured analysis to deepen the understanding of TikTok as an MH platform and contextualize its impact on MH discourse and users.

4.1 What TikTok Does Well

Several takeaways highlight how the platform provides a unique environment that benefits MH content.

4.1.1 Tailoring MH Content. As previous research indicated by Zhang and Liu, personalized content on TikTok offers novelty and serendipity [35]. Insights from my interviews align with this in that TikTok's algorithmic tailoring of content to individual users also applies to MH content. I learned that although initially met with skepticism by some participants, this feature gradually gained acceptance as users recognized its ability to align content with their interests and experiences. Seeing other people's opinions in the comments also builds a sense of community, and extends to influencing personal views. This personalized approach sets the stage for understanding how the platform delivers and enables MH content to thrive. TikTok successfully generates a feeling where users feel understood by the app in that it shows videos that fit the user's current situations and moods.

4.1.2 Building Trust. This personalized approach benefits both viewers and creators. My findings agree with previous research, where users see TikTok as a safe space, providing a sense of trust

[26, 27]. From a creator’s perspective, the trust in TikTok’s algorithmic delivery mechanism means that they can confidently share, at times, very personal MH advice, knowing their content will reach the intended audience, creating a sense of security for creators and thus allowing for vulnerability. This level of assurance contributes to the platform’s appeal to those seeking to share their MH experience. It ultimately helps foster an open and accepting environment. Similarly, I have learned that viewers trust TikTok’s algorithm, in particular, only to deliver relevant content. This trust creates a sense of safety, empowering users to open up about and explore their potential MH experiences without fearing judgment that they might otherwise encounter in a more close-knit SM. This combination of algorithmic delivery and perceived safety encourages individuals to explore and be open to their vulnerabilities.

4.1.3 Fostering Vulnerability and Perceived Authenticity. My findings emphasize the significance of personalized content, particularly in the context of MH discussions. The effectiveness of TikTok’s algorithm in gauging users’ moods and delivering timely MH content contributes to users exploring topics they might not typically engage with. The precise algorithmic assessment plays a pivotal role in encouraging users to delve into their vulnerabilities and engage with MH content. Moreover, my research underscores the importance of perceived authenticity and openness in cultivating a supportive environment for MH discussions on TikTok. The platform’s culture of personal storytelling coupled with community interactions, contributes to an environment with minimal MH stigma. This combination of personalized content and a supportive community fosters an atmosphere where users feel encouraged to be open and vulnerable about MH.

4.2 Where TikTok Falls Short

TikTok’s synergy with MH promotion and its personalized algorithmic content delivery also present significant challenges.

4.2.1 Insufficient Transparency. The app needs to be more transparent in how some of its features work or what impact a user action can have. This finding agrees with previous research conducted by Eslami et al. and [14]. While users believe liking a post influences what gets recommended, following a creator has said not to change the viewing experience (on the FYP). This uncertainty leaves many users needing clarification about what kind of consequences some of their actions have on the app, as well as feeling suspicious about whether there is censorship and filtering of comments and thus curated discussions and who enforces this filtering, TikTok or the creators.

4.2.2 Algorithmic Trust and Reduced Critical Reflection. Many users strongly believed in the platform’s understanding of their preferences and interests. This trust in the algorithm can discourage critical reflection on the information provided, as demonstrated in a study by Greene et al. and [16]. When beliefs in algorithmic suggestions go to lengths where users unquestioningly believe anything to be true that the algorithm tells them about their persona, critical engagement with the content is crucial. However, the app does not currently host any elements of critical reflection, nor is the validity and verification of information granted. These findings align with prior research highlighting users struggling to call

out misinformation [11, 23, 30]. This lack of verification can be detrimental if the shared information about, e.g., mental illnesses is incorrect or too abstracted and skewed to be presentable on the app. The algorithm’s bubble effect was observed to solidify users’ beliefs rather than encourage critical discussion. While TikTok helps users of an MH community feel understood, it might also give users a wrong sense of where the public opinion stands.

4.2.3 Intentions and Responsibility. My participants had mixed views on TikTok’s true intentions concerning MH content. TikTok’s role as an MH platform warrants critical examination, as its algorithms often prioritize specific niche performance. However, the potential for algorithmic optimization for virality raises concerns about MH content potentially losing its focus on user well-being. Knowing from previous research by Trepte and Reinecke that the perceived rewards of self-disclosure can affect how and why creators self-disclose, the chase for virality remains a valid concern, supported by prior research [34]. Participants also grappled with the question of responsibility concerning the content they consumed on TikTok. While the interviewees believed viewers bear responsibility for content consumption on the app, the platform’s algorithmic nature significantly influences the content delivered to users.

4.2.4 Short Video Format Caveats. From talking to my participants, I understood that they did not perceive these short clips on TikTok as suitable for extensive and in-depth treatments of MH topics. Users generally view TikTok as a platform for entertainment and quick consumption rather than in-depth learning or research. It makes sense why none of the participants would refer to TikTok to perform more extensive research on a topic, including MH. Ultimately, it shows that the platform’s emphasis on brevity and user engagement leads to content that needs more substance and depth. This brevity in which content gets presented means that much information merely scratches a topic’s surface level. Hence, it is also why some users believe the platform glorifies the normalization of potentially harmful behaviors. It creates awareness of MH conditions. Still, it does not provide users with needed follow-up steps to seek treatment.

4.3 Design Implications

Several design implications are elaborated on to try and optimize the platform’s role as an MH platform.

4.3.1 Transparency on Actions. Users’ reports of dissatisfaction with some of the recommended videos highlight the need for TikTok to improve transparency in its algorithmic suggestions. TikTok should either enhance transparency about its algorithm or empower users with more active control over their viewing experiences. The app should support users in their desire to fully understand the complexities of how their interactions with the platform shape the recommendations they receive. TikTok could provide users with short explanations of how their algorithm learns through following, liking, and other activities.

4.3.2 Enhancing User Support for Triggering Content. The platform should acknowledge the importance of considering the challenges

that people of vulnerable communities, potentially trauma survivors, face in online spaces, as discussed by Randazzo and Ammari and [25] and enhance their support in interacting with such content. Regarding more active user controls, TikTok should explore strategies to assist users in managing their exposure to sensitive content without compromising the platform's unique appeal. I have learned that users often guard themselves against triggering topics simply by skipping specific videos they feel might be triggering. This risk poses a need for TikTok to provide support mechanisms.

I propose to address this problem by introducing small banners that inform users about what the video addresses, similar to how videos featured banners during the COVID-19 pandemic when their content addressed topics related to that. Other users could flag and classify specific videos on what information they contain, therefore leveraging the power of the community to help classify specific videos. Another way to support users interacting with sensitive content is to implement warning flags, as TikTok currently has them for sensitive content. Rather than censoring content, TikTok could extend its existing content warning flag system to feature more categories, such as MH topics. With various flag categories, the system could help users identify and brace themselves for potentially sensitive content, ultimately giving users back some degree of power over content exposure. However, it remains to be seen whether an extensive use of flags would impede TikTok's explorative and entertaining nature.

4.3.3 Information Quality and Verification. Another issue concerns the quality and validity of information about MH on TikTok. As previous research has identified, many accounts provide a potential means to make MH information more accessible. However, these accounts are not subjected to credibility checks [24]. TikTok's current model needs features for verifying the accuracy of shared information. TikTok could adopt a system akin to the one introduced by X (formerly known as Twitter) called Community Notes to create awareness and promote content accuracy. The system, seen in Figure 1, is a collaborative way to add helpful context to posts and provide better information. Similar to the system on X, the verification system could be community-based, with users flagging dubious content that would be cross-verified by other users and independent entities. Another way to address the normalization of harmful behaviors and false information would be for TikTok to create awareness about symptoms by redirecting consumers to appropriate resources hosted within the app. Initiatives like a certified creator's program could incentivize creators to produce authentic and valuable MH content, enhancing user access to information and the platform's credibility and reputation as a trustworthy entity.

These design implications offer a roadmap for TikTok to navigate its evolving role as a platform for MH discussions. Balancing the need for informative, responsible content with user engagement and entertainment remains a critical challenge in TikTok's ongoing journey to fostering awareness and openness about MH issues.

5 LIMITATIONS AND CONCLUSION

The study provides valuable insights into the dynamics of MH content on TikTok but also has inherent limitations. Relying on interviews with a single MH content creator restricts the representation

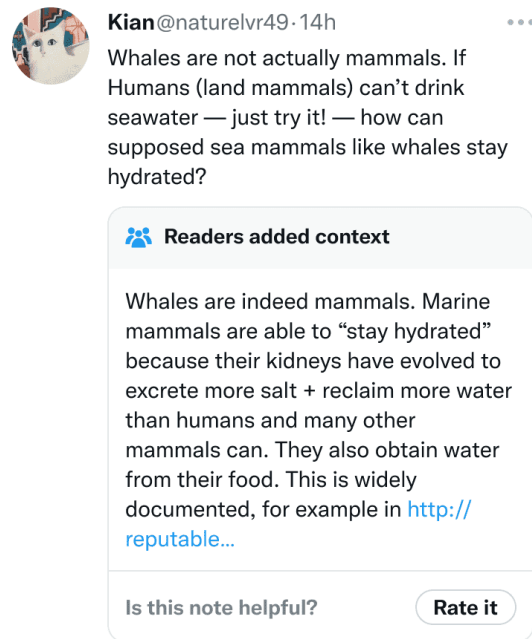


Figure 1: Example of X's Community Notes feature. Illustration by X [3]

of diverse perspectives within the larger creator population. Demographically, a majority of participants were from the same country, and held education degrees, limiting the findings' applicability to a broader demographic. The age range of 20-30 of my interviewed users with prior SM experience may not reflect how younger TikTok users engage with MH content. API restrictions in my region hindered comprehensive data collection, limiting access to engagement metrics and user behaviors. Recruitment solely through comments, due to the absence of an API, potentially resulted in a restricted sample size. Finally, privacy concerns prevented gathering specific MH condition information, possibly limiting the study's breadth.

In conclusion, this research provides insights into TikTok's complex role in MH discussions, offering concise design implications. As TikTok evolves, maintaining its value as a space for meaningful MH and societal discussions is crucial. TikTok's algorithm and user dynamics foster a supportive environment for MH conversations, encouraging openness and community building, especially among its young user base. However, challenges lack of information verification and transparency, and limitations in content depth. Anonymity on TikTok has a dual nature, allowing expression but also enabling exploitation, staining the platform's reputation in MH discussions. To address these challenges, proposed design implications focus on transparency, warning flags for sensitive content, and verification of MH information quality.

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